

Keys to Mastery|

The art of speedtyping



Intro



Honestly, I think *speedtyping* (or speed typing, I guess) or competitive typing is a pretty niche thing. I mean, people probably don't enjoy typing in general or take it seriously enough to want to improve. So if you're actually into speedtyping—or just enjoy the feel of typing and keyboards—I'd be pretty proud of you. At the end of the day we can all agree that "speedtyping" is pretty much just typing fast. There's no set WPM that counts as fast. Personally for me, I would say that speedtyping is really just about pushing yourself to type as quickly as you can or want to.

In this zine, I'll share about my experiences through my own typing journey, the habits and techniques that actually helped me improve, and the mindset I had. I'll also share some resources and my own thoughts.

Personal Journey

So I started getting serious trying to improve my typing speed in 2020. Don't exactly remember *why* but I guess it makes sense that it was the start of the pandemic. I do remember getting introduced to typing (to get faster) when I was in elementary, maybe grade 3 or 4. That's probably the first time I was introduced to touch typing (aka blind typing). However, I just suddenly seemed to gain motivation to actually learn touch typing in 2020.

My strat at first was probably just scouring over the internet typing websites. That's when I knew how touch typing actually worked. One of the very first websites I tried was [typing.academy](#), but looking back now I feel like this website is actually pretty bad for a typing website. Any typing website that wants you to pay for them for a typing course is pretty much a waste of money.



Personal Journey

You don't have to *pay* to improve. There are tons of free websites that'll help you so much more than these paid websites.

The website that *actually* worked for me was keybr.com. This was where I finally improved so much. It really lets you get a feel for touch typing, and personally I found its statistics interesting, and it was one of the things that motivated me to continue since I felt like I was improving.

Occasionally I'd watch videos on youtube about how to improve touch typing and people who are actually fast. One of the first videos was pretty much just someone trying out keybr and he showed his results after one month of practicing. I was impressed by that and wanted to give keybr a try. I really like the design and experience of the website and instantly got hooked on it. This was also when I was really into the idea of muscle memory.



Personal Journey

The first time I used keybr was around August of 2020 and I practiced around an average of 30 to 60 minutes. I think now that was overpracticing, but I guess I was just desperate to improve and enjoyed the process. After being somewhat consistent for 2 weeks, I went from averaging about 40 WPM to 70 WPM. That was really a big jump for me that time. For some reason, though, I didn't practice consistently for months until nearly a year later. I still improved quite a bit, however (averaged ~90 WPM). Eventually I was able to break the 100 WPM border around mid of 2021, and that was also when I discovered monkeytype.com. I thought monkeytype was really cool and liked the minimalistic design, so I eventually switched to it. Although I still maintained keybr until switching completely to monkeytype (around the end of 2022). After that I was pretty satisfied being able to average more than 100 WPM, around 120-130 WPM (in monkeytype 60s).



Habits and Techniques

QWERTY

Ok I guess I did say that there's no specific WPM that's considered fast at the start. However, you *can* be fast relative to others. Most people average ~40 WPM. Honestly, your WPM would actually really depend on the conditions. A 60-second test would be more accurate than a 15-second test and also test your endurance. 15-second or even 10 word tests just show your *burst speed*. Punctuation and numbers also would matter, but personally I just use letters when practicing and comparing my speed. Also FYI WPM is assumed to be 5 characters per word.

Remember: always prioritize **accuracy** first before speed. Touch typing is probably the most optimized technique for typing, so I'd recommend that. You don't have to use ALL 10 fingers; most people who touch type probably only use 9 fingers (only using the dominant thumb for the spacebar), including me.

Habits and Techniques

QWERTY

The fundamentals of touch typing are mainly *typing without looking* and using 9-10 fingers (7-8 fingers without pinky). I just remember some sites or people from Reddit saying using two thumbs for space would become confusing, especially at high speeds. Personally, I only use my dominant (right) thumb for the spacebar. However, I've seen some people avoiding using their pinky finger (including 150+ WPM) to reduce strain, or since it has "limited motion". That should be fine as long as you're comfortable with it. But personally, as someone who does use my pinkies to type, I think you'd actually be sacrificing some potential.

I'd say practicing 15 minutes consistently every day is pretty good already to notice improvements. Also, when trying to practice touch typing, *really* try to type without looking at the keyboard. This will help build muscle memory.



Habits and Techniques

QWERTY

It'll feel pretty slow and painful at first, but it will be worth it, and you'll really see improvements once you develop total muscle memory for each key. I think you shouldn't really use multiplayer typing websites (like typeracer) to actually improve. I'd normally just do it for fun and would rather practice mostly by myself. I also think practicing on just letters is enough, really. You can practice numbers and punctuation if you want; they'd still be pretty useful in actual situations.

The main thing really is **consistency**. I've heard something like this multiple times before, and I totally agree: It's better to practice 15 minutes a day, 5 days a week, than to practice for an hour and a half, 1 day a week.

Motivation and Mastery

CTRL

I'd say **100 WPM** is a solid milestone to aim for. Apparently only about the top 1-5% of people who type reach this speed. The thing that really motivated me to keep improving was knowing that I was improving and seeing my progress. Just looking at those statistics from keybr really made me feel like there was tangible improvement.

Another thing that can boost motivation is finding a keyboard you actually enjoy using. Customizing or picking a good one (especially a mechanical) can really pull you deeper into the hobby. Daily streaks and goals (like 15 mins a day) also helped me stay consistent.



I heard about Barbara Blackburn being the “world's fastest typist” before using the Dvorak layout. According to Guinness, she could hold 150 WPM for 50 minutes straight (37,500 keystrokes) and peak at 170 WPM. Crazy numbers—but keep in mind, this was way before the 2000s. I used to be super impressed, and I still kinda am, but typing has come a long way since then. 150 WPM is rare, but it's not unreachable and has become more common (I mean, I've hit it myself).

Even though QWERTY is really, really old, it's still the most popular, and even the fastest typists use it. It's better to stick to one layout that you find comfortable rather than learn another one. You may be able to switch to layouts like Dvorak or Colemak, but it's just not going to actually make you faster immediately; it mostly just makes you more comfortable and reduces strain.

However, Dvorak can probably be rewarding if you really have the patience to reach your QWERTY speed. Dvorak is also probably good to switch to early on your journey—when you're just starting out—but you also have to be aware of the drawbacks of this: there will be situations where you really have to use QWERTY for things, or it would be inconvenient to use Dvorak. So you either should be flexible using QWERTY and Dvorak, or be able to find a reliable workaround.

Beyond standard touch typing (advanced), there are also ways to tweak your fingerings to optimize certain words—especially ones that repeat the same finger in the default layout. I'm still experimenting with this myself on a few words.

Resources



Practice

- keybr.com – Great starting point for learning touch typing
- monkeytype.com – Highly customizable, my main now
 - *My personal bests (as of Sept 2025, CreepetPer): 183|15s, 155|60s, 220|10 words*
- 10fastfingers.com – I've used this a long time ago. Still seems popular with some really fast typists.

Competitive

- play.typeracer.com – OG typing race site, around since 2008
- keydash.io – newer site, released 2020

Thanks for reading.

[Press any key to continue...]

.....[Larence Conde, Sep. 2025]